Afghanistan was a victim of India-Pakistan rivalry, Karzai also offered to mediate between the two South Asian rivals if they would agree. The partisans were disappointed and worried about what course Afghanistan would take if Karzai continued to harbor doubts about India's stance on Afghanistan. Eventually these differences were smoothened as Karzai's initial outreach to Pakistan failed in light of the Taliban's resurgence. Converting him into a fierce critic of the Pakistan army, the Taliban's revival pushed Karzai into an embrace with India. So much so that he admitted at a 2012 press meet in New Delhi that India had supported Afghanistan 'a lot in the security sector'.[76] When pushed by a senior Indian journalist to explicate how, Karzai bluntly and wittily replied, 'if I tell that, then it will not remain a secret'.[77] Concerned that he might get assassinated, India, in collaboration with the NDS, had contributed in providing him a covert security cover (the extent and nature of which is unknown). Karzai's political dexterity and mistrust in Pakistan had transformed him, somewhat, into the twenty-first-century avatar of Najibullah.

Top US officials had noted this aspect of India's partisan tilt towards Karzai. US Vice President Joe Biden, in a briefing about the Afghan war to president Obama, underlined: 'what Pakistan doesn't want, as a matter of faith, is a unified Afghan government that is led by a Pashtun sympathetic to India', whereas Karzai was just that kind of Pashtun.[78] Such partisan support for Karzai and his supporters came to be known unofficially in Indian policy circles as the 'Najibullah Model'. The MEA's basic line in Afghanistan, according to Pramit Pal Chaudhuri, former member of the NSAB, was—'can we have another Najibullah in Kabul?'[79] Though not a formal policy announcement, this was allegedly, the driving force behind supporting Karzai to the hilt when his relations soured with the West. Given the influence of partisans in India's establishment and the fondness with which Najibullah was looked upon in the 1980s, it was reasonable to expect New Delhi to desire for the 'Najibullah Model' as the US started planning a withdrawal. Unlike the early 1990s when India played a defensive game in the wake of the Soviet withdrawal, in 2014, India worked very well with the Pasthuns, especially Karzai. As an Indian analyst observed, 'India today [in 2013], more than ever in the history of Independent India, has a degree of influence in the Pashtun lands', he asserted.[80] Karzai and the villages in south and